

ANI

PREPPING FOR CHEER
Artisans setting up stalls at the state government-organised shopping festival in Kolkata, Sept. 20

Kolkata afternoon, he sits in his shop crammed with new material, waiting for customers. "During this season, my sales usually touch Rs 5,000 to Rs 7,000 daily. But now I am barely making Rs 3,000," Saha tells INDIA TODAY.

According to data from the Confederation of West Bengal Trade Associations (CWBTA), an apex body of retailers, business has reduced by 25 to 30 per cent from last year. "There have been multiple contributory factors. The protests are one, but we must take the negative impact of incessant rains and the subsequent floods into account as well," says Sushil Poddar, president of CWBTA.

While the traditional markets are bearing the brunt of this unprecedented lag in festive cheer, the shopping malls aren't faring any better. Two large Kolkata malls, Acropolis and South City, confirmed they have taken a hit. The former witnessed a slump of 30 per cent in average footfall on the weekends, the latter has seen a dip of 20 per cent. Both malls have come up with promotional ideas. Subhadip Basu, general manager of Acropolis, has announced a campaign where a shopper can win a trolley bag against shopping for a certain amount. "Though footfall and sales are still lower than 2023, we are seeing a rise in shopping as families are buying eagerly awaited shoes and clothes for children," says Basu. Dip Biswas, head of operations of South City mall, has a plan too. Like other establishments, South City puts up grand puja décor to attract people. Usually the decorations are completed around Mahalaya—a week before Durga Puja. This year, Biswas plans to start a week earlier.

A silver lining appeared on September 19, when the protesting junior doctors called off their 42-day-long ceasework, leading traders to hope that people would change their minds. In some cases, the upward trend has begun. Ranjan Roy, president of Hatibagan Merchant Welfare Association, says footfalls increased since Sunday, September 15.

The depressed mood had affected the volume of corporate sponsorships on which most big/ medium puja organisers have come to depend. The Forum for Durgotsab, the largest association of puja organisers in Kolkata with over 500 members, has seen around 25 per cent less sponsorships so far, in spite of receiving a massive show of advance interest by advertisers/ sponsors. They, too, are living in hope. "The response in June was so huge that each of us could organise two pujas if that materialised. But the RG Kar incident changed everything," says Saswata Das, secretary of the forum. But Das, too, affirms that in the past few days the mood has subtly changed and money has started coming in. "All of us stand with the demand for justice. But we hope that by the blessings of the goddess, the economic implications aren't too harsh," Das said.

Tens of thousands thronged the city-wide shopping festival that the state government organised in association with the CWBT between September 20 and 24. Everyone feels things will improve vastly in the final run-up to the pujas. It just may not be enough to recover the initial loss in business. ■

COLD SPIRIT

- **Bengal's Rs 50,000 crore Durga Puja economy is badly hit by the sombre mood of people weighed down by the RG Kar incident, affecting livelihoods**
- **Top shopping areas, malls see over 25 per cent fall in sales; corporate sponsorships also down**
- **In the final run-up to the pujas, business is picking up but it might be too late to fully recover losses**